

The Quick Counterplan Outline

The goal of this document is to give you a concise guide on how you construct and argue a counterplan. The better you are at predicting what the Affirmative might run with their plan, the more success you will get in crafting and executing your Counter Plans.

To Start:

The Affirmative team should have constructed their case in the following ways:

1. Presented a legitimate argument(s) containing **significant harms**, which have well-articulated impact(s).
2. A **Plan** presented with all the necessary elements. (Mandate (text), Actor, Enforcement, Funding, and Timeline for implementation)
3. There is a **clearly articulated barrier** demonstrating why the plan is needed (Inherency).

The reason why these elements are needed is because it allows you as the Negative team to draw a better distinction between the two proposals.

What a Counterplan (CP) needs (should be presented in the Leader Speech):

1. On face, a CP needs all the same components of a regular plan. Thus, a CP is vulnerable and can be attacked the same way. For example, arguments about plan shifts, vagueness, A-Specs, E-Specs, Funding Specs, and solvency deficits can be made by the Affirmative team against a Negative team's CP. The easiest way to attack a plan or CP is because some or all the elements of it are vague. Don't make that mistake.
2. CPs must also have the following features:
 - a. The CP must **not be topical**.
 - i. The resolution is used to divide the ground in the debate, which requires the Affirmative team to develop a plan that meets every definition contained
 - b. The CP must be **competitive**.

This standard requires that the Negative team to show that if both the Plan and CP were adopted simultaneously it would **be impossible, undesired, or unnecessary**. Competition can be shown through a couple different ways.

 - i. Mutual exclusivity: The plan and CP cannot be done at the same time. (i.e. Plan requires "personal mandate for healthcare," CP "bans the personal mandate")
 - ii. Net beneficial: CP is competitive, under this standard, if it is undesirable to do both the CP and/or the Plan at the same time. Meeting this standard is showing that the CP is the best option of all the potential options on the table.
 - iii. Solvency: This standard is demonstrated by arguing that the CP can solve the Affirmative's harms. If the harms remain after the adoption of the CP, it is not a competitive option.

- c. CP must solve the Affirmative's need.
 - i. CP rejects Affirmative plan on grounds that there is a better way to solve the significant harms of the Affirmative's case. CP does not have to solve 100% of the Affirmative's harms in the same way that the Plan does not have to solve 100% either, however, it must solve a substantial portion of the harms.
- d. CP must at minimum be equally advantageous.
 - i. Net benefit: The CP should capture most of the Affirmatives' advantages, ideally since your CP should be solving the same harm. If not, your CP should capture significant benefits. In addition, a way to make your CP more advantageous would be to argue an independent advantage
 - ii. Avoid Plan specific disadvantages; If the Plan has a significant cost to it (which would be a disadvantage to the plan), and your CP avoids that cost, that disadvantage will TURN to become an advantage to the CP.

Sample Counterplan Shell:

Counter Plan: Text of Plan (specifically)

Plank One: Agency (Who enacts plan?)

Plank Two: Enforcement (Who ensures the plan is carried out?)

Plank Three: Funding (Who and how is it paid for?)

Observation One: Non-Topicality (What term(s) of the resolution does the CP violate? Explain why the counterplan is not topical)

Observation Two: Competition Mutual Exclusivity (explain why the plan and counter plan cannot both be adopted)

Observation Three: CP Solvency (How does this CP solve for the Affirmative's Harms?)

Advantages of the CP: present all of the benefits of the CP (the net benefits, or Disad turns).

Defending the CP:

- The CP can be attacked in several ways, and some forethought should be put into defense before reading the plan (if possible):
 - Traditional lines of attack (these are also attacks that can be made on Plan):
 - Plan shifts: If what is read during the LO speech changes during the MO speech, you are likely to be hit with a shift argument. It is best to write out the CP plan text on a separate sheet of paper so it can be directly referred to during the debate.
 - Vagueness: Avoid this argument by have a very specific plan text that is easy to understand and ultimately defend. You have to know what your plan does, how it works, and be able to explain that clearly.
 - A-Specs: Agent Specification arguments center around not knowing who specifically enacts your plan. Be clear about who does this and why.

- E-Specs: Enforcement Specification arguments center around not knowing who specifically implements and ensures the plan is executed. This is a key point in determining solvency. Be clear about who does this and why.
- Funding Specs: The specification arguments deal with how the CP is funded. Because offense can be generated around the idea of how much something costs, where that money comes from, what is traded off to afford it, etc. You need to specify and be ready to defend how the CP is funded.
- Solvency deficits: These arguments center around the idea that the Plan or CP must demonstrably solve the harms articulated. The main question to ask, and be prepared to answer if challenged is, ‘How do we know this plan solves the problem?’ Is there an expert that has talked about this in the past? Or are there a series of logical assumptions that are being made?
- Arguments of ***Permutation***: Permutations test the mutual exclusivity competition of a CP. These are the most common types of
 - Intrinsic Permutations (typically combines both the Plan and CP)
 - Perm—Do Both: This typically involves combining the Plan and the CP together. Affirmative will argue that there is not sufficient competition, not mutual exclusivity, and ***no specific reason why both options cannot be done together.***
 - Perm—Do Plan then CP (or CP then Plan): This again shows that
 - Severance Permutations (typically most of the Plan and CP, but the perm “severs” (leaves out) a part of the plan)
 - Perm—Do Both, except: Some combination of the Plan and CP, but with some carve out that typically avoids some kind of Disadvantage.
 - Burdens when Perms are presented: At the end of the debate involving Perm arguments, there will be at least three policy options; the original Plan, the CP, and any number of Perm plans. Typically, the Affirmative will win the debate if they prove either the Plan or any of the Perms to be the preferable policy option. Negative will win if it proves that the CP is the most preferable policy option. Typically, in addition to the CP the Negative team will present a number of disadvantages that will stick to the Plan, and any of the Perms but will not hit the CP.